for maintenance. Rails supports this need with dynamic layouts. If the parameter to the `layout` declaration is a symbol, it's taken to be the name of a controller instance method that returns the name of the layout to be used:

```
class StoreController < ApplicationController

  layout :determine_layout
  # ...
  private

  def determine_layout
    if Store.is_closed?
      "store_down"
    else
      "standard"
    end
  end
end
```

Subclasses of a controller use the parent's layout unless they override it using the `layout` directive. Finally, individual actions can choose to render using a specific layout (or with no layout at all) by passing `render` the `:layout` option:

```
def rss
  render(layout: false)   # never use a layout
end
def checkout
  render(layout: "layouts/simple")
end
```

Passing Data to Layouts

Layouts have access to all the same data that's available to conventional templates. In addition, any instance variables set in the normal template will be available in the layout (because the regular template is rendered before the layout is invoked). This might be used to parameterize headings or menus in the layout. For example, the layout might contain this:

```
<html>
  <head>
    <title><%= @title %></title>
    <%= stylesheet_link_tag 'scaffold' %>
```